

QED | SHANKAR AIYAR

Indian Power League

The resemblance is uncanny. The din, the cacophony, the mindgames, tactics, strategies, symbols, songs, slogans, stars and sponsors, the cheerleaders and the hoopla... The Indian Power League is not unlike the Indian Premier League. Yet this is serious stuff. Yes there will be the spin-masters bowling googlies, parties will deploy pinch hitters and leaders will invoke reverse swing, but in this game the winners are decided by those who vote, not those who play. At the end of this nine-week festival of democracy, India and Indians are expected to emerge winners. At least we all believe so. But look at the field and you wonder if there will be any winners at all.

Psephology has long since replaced ideology, conviction is a matter of convenience and the etymology of power is defined by expediency. Look at the options available to the Indian voter to consider bestowing the divine right to rule. No, I don't think anyone is expecting superhumans and a super-agenda, but surely the Indian voters deserve a semblance of confidence in who they will be voting for.

The principal opposition party has anointed a captain but there is no sign of a team, or team spirit. The cliché, "The party with differences", which best describes the BJP since 2004, sounds charitable now. It isn't surprising that one of its oldest allies has left the NDA. What is surprising is that others are still with it. The Grand Old Party is a formidable team but nobody quite knows who will be the next prime minister. Yes, individuals have said

Manmohan Singh will be the natural choice but the party itself has been suspiciously silent. The top job is not a badge of honour but a negotiable instrument to balance the arithmetic of politics in the quest for

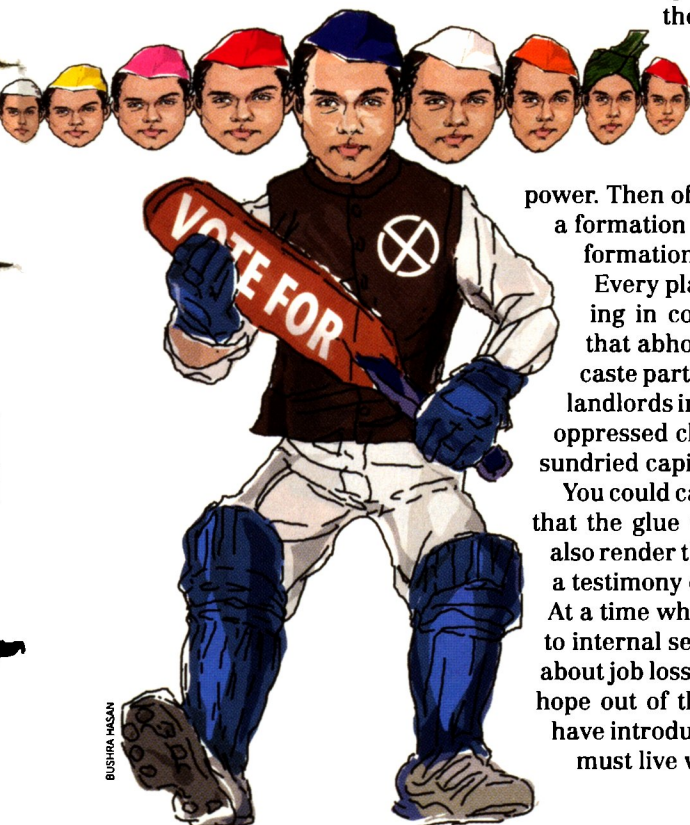
power. Then of course there is the third team, a formation that has no name as yet. It is a formation of captains looking for a team.

Every player on that platform has nothing in common with the other. Parties that abhor caste politics along with one-caste parties, fronts that represent feudal landlords in sync with those who represent oppressed classes, communists in bed with sundried capitalists.

You could call it the perfect coalition except that the glue that brings them together will also render them asunder. Their existence is a testimony on the state of national parties. At a time when India is coping with threats to internal security and Indians are worried about job losses, the political class has edited hope out of the equation. India's politicians have introduced a new challenge the people must live with: low expectations.

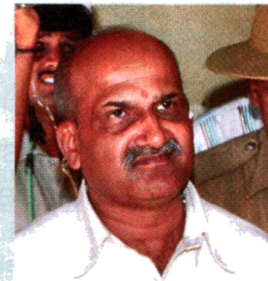


THE POLITICAL CLASS HAS EDITED HOPE OUT OF THE EQUATION AND INTRODUCED A NEW CHALLENGE INDIANS MUST LIVE WITH: LOW EXPECTATIONS



SIGNPOSTS

BANNED: Sri Rama Sene chief **Pramod Muthalik**, by the Dakshina Kannada deputy commissioner, from entering the district for one year for



his inflammatory statements after the attack on girls in a Mangalore pub.

WON: By golfer **Gaganjeet Bhullar**, 20, the PGTI Players' Championship in Panchkula. He is the youngest winner on the PGTI tour.

APPOINTED: **Sharat Sabharwal** as the next high commissioner to Pakistan. He is currently special secretary in the MEA and will succeed Satyabrata Pal.

DIED: Sports secretary **Sudhir Nath**, 56. As director, enforcement, he had led the probe into the controversial oil-for-food scam in Iraq which was unearthed by the Volcker Committee of the United Nations.

